

Athabasca oil sands, Canada

The enormous Athabasca oil reserves are in the form of oil shale on the land's surface. To get the oil out of oil shale needs huge amounts of water and energy and causes far more environmental destruction per barrel of oil than normal drilling.

North Sea
Contains western Europe's largest oil and natural gas reserves.

How long left?

Fossil fuels are used up faster all the time, and one day the world's fuel reserves—the fuels remaining in the ground—will run out. Estimates of the size of the fuel reserves go up as well as down, as old reserves are used up and new ones are discovered. Below are the latest estimates of how long they will last.



Texas gas fields

The US is the world's largest producer of gas. Texas provides almost one-quarter of the US's gas from both onshore and offshore fields.

US

Americans consume about 16% of the world's fossil fuel energy.

Trinidad and Tobago

Natural gas consumption per person is the highest in the world, and gas reserves are declining fast.

Venezuela

Has possibly the greatest amount of oil of any single country. Over 17 percent of global reserves are found here.

Nigeria

The largest producer of oil in Africa, but conflict and a lack of resources limit production.

Falkland Islands

Surveys show that around the British-controlled Falkland Islands there may be double the amount of oil as in the North Sea. Argentina claims a right to the islands and to the oil.

Fossil fuels

More than four-fifths of the world's energy comes from fossil fuels: oil, natural gas, and coal. These are the remains of plants and other life-forms, buried for millions of years. When burned, they release energy, but also waste gases, which pollute the atmosphere.

**MOST FOSSIL FUELS
WERE FORMED
300–360 MILLION
YEARS AGO**